



role in the campaign, but he kept the squad's spirits up and, when the dust settled, looked the happiest, basking in the success of his teammates. "Every player is special, even those on the bench," Suryakumar said.

Even if India's successful title defence seemed inevitable, it was never a smooth ride. USA tested the host, the loss to South Africa offered a reality check, and both West Indies and England proved to be tough opponents. Against men from the Old Blighty, it needed Bumrah and Hardik Pandya's death overs to stymie the chase even as Jacob Bethell threatened to run away with the game.

Champion units are flexible and always have a Plan B. Samson was part of this alternate vision. At one point, India was shelling catches, but in the crunch, the same outfit was plucking blinders. The seamers had their share of wides too, but often these issues were masked as Bumrah, with 14 wickets, stemmed the flow of runs.

Mystery spinner Varun

Chakaravarthy too had 14 scalps, though he had a rough phase towards the end as batters flung everything, including the kitchen sink, at him. Both Bumrah and Varun topped the wickets list in the championship. "All the players need to be comfortable, they should be able to say what they want to say," Suryakumar said while revealing a democratic change-room.

The 'winner takes all' theme was reinforced when Gambhir said that trophies are more important than milestones. The southpaw, who excelled in the finals of the 2007 ICC T20 and 2011 World Cup, surely knows what matters to the team. Be it a young Arshdeep Singh or a seasoned Suryakumar, everyone

supported each other.

In the blue shade, India remains the team to beat, especially in T20Is. Its batting has the same effect that the West Indians once exuded when they had Gordon Greenidge, Vivian Richards and Clive Lloyd in their ranks. India's bowling may still ride on Bumrah, but men like Arshdeep, Hardik and Axar showed that when it comes to a crisis, they will all rise together.

India's fifth World Cup victory, and the third in T20Is, is a validation of the team's growth. The Test side may be nursing a slump after losses at home against New Zealand and South Africa, but in coloured clothing, India remains a many-splendoured team.

« No team had ever retained the title or won at home in the ICC T20 World Cup. India busted both those trends. »